
Planning and Structuring of Official Report Writing

A Learning Guide for NSO Nepal Staff

National Statistics Office (NSO) Nepal
Government of Nepal

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Agenda

Step	Topic
1	The Landscape of Official Reports
2	Choosing the Right Report for the Right Situation
3	Structuring the Outline
4	What to Include in Each Section
5	Writing with Statistical Precision
6	Review, Quality Assurance & Finalization
7	Synthesis: From Blank Page to Published Report
.	Summary & Next Steps

Step 1 of 7

The Landscape of Official Reports

Understanding the types of official and statistical reports, their purposes, and how they differ from general writing.

What Is an “Official Report”?

An official report is a **structured, purposeful document** that communicates factual information to a defined audience. Unlike general writing, official reports must be:

Property	Meaning
Accurate	Numbers and facts are verified
Objective	Free from personal opinion
Neutral in tone	Descriptive, not persuasive
Traceable	Claims backed by data or citations

For NSO Nepal, reports are the primary channel for sharing national statistics with government, media, researchers, and international partners.

8 Types of Official and Statistical Reports

#	Report Type	Core Purpose	Primary Audience
1	Statistical Bulletin	Publish key indicators (CPI, GDP)	Government, media, public
2	Press Release	Announce findings quickly & accessibly	Media, general public
3	Statistical Abstract	Comprehensive data across sectors	Researchers, planners
4	Analytical / Thematic Report	In-depth topic analysis	Policymakers, donors
5	Census / Survey Report	Full methodology & findings	All stakeholders
6	Administrative Report	Progress updates, minutes	NSO management
7	Technical / Methodology Report	How data was collected & processed	Statisticians
8	Policy Brief	Action-oriented summary	Ministers, officials

Key Report Types — At a Glance

Statistical Bulletin

Fixed-schedule publication (monthly, quarterly, annually). Numbers, tables, brief commentary.

Example: Nepal CPI — Monthly Bulletin

Press Release

1–2 page announcement for journalists & public. Simple, direct, jargon-free.

First public-facing document alongside any major release.

Census / Survey Report

Most comprehensive type. Covers background, methodology, findings, annexes.

Example: NPHC 2078 — National Report

Analytical / Thematic Report

Explains *what the numbers mean*.

Includes context, comparisons, sometimes recommendations.

Policy Brief

2–4 pages. Explicitly recommends action. A Minister should be able to read it in **5 minutes**.

Technical / Methodology Report

For statisticians and peer institutions. Explains sampling design, processing steps, caveats.

Why Does the Distinction Matter?

Each report type has **different rules** for:

- **Length** — from 1 page (press release) to 300+ pages (census report)
- **Tone** — technical vs. plain language
- **Structure** — free-form vs. fixed template
- **Audience** — statisticians vs. journalists vs. ministers

Common mistakes: Writing a press release that reads like a methodology report, or burying a policy brief's recommendation on page 10. Choosing the wrong report type wastes time and reduces impact.

Key Takeaway: The first decision in any writing task is — *What kind of report is this, and who is it for?*

Step 2 of 7

Choosing the Right Report for the Right Situation

How to decide which report type to write based on audience, purpose, and occasion.

Ask Three Questions First

Before writing a single word, answer these:

1. Who is my audience?

Journalists? Ministers? Statisticians? The general public?

2. What do I want from them?

To report the news? To make a policy decision? To replicate our methodology?

3. What is the urgency and occasion?

Scheduled release? One-time survey result? Emergency announcement?

Your answers point directly to the right report type.

Decision Guide: When to Write What

Situation	Best Report Type
Monthly/quarterly data ready (CPI, trade, employment)	Statistical Bulletin
Publishing a bulletin and want media coverage	Press Release (<i>alongside bulletin</i>)
Minister needs a 5-minute read before a meeting	Policy Brief
Completed a national census or survey	Census / Survey Report
Analysing trends across multiple indicators over time	Analytical / Thematic Report
Peer institution asks how you collected your data	Technical / Methodology Report
Briefing your director on project progress	Administrative / Internal Report
International donor wants a country data summary	Statistical Abstract / Compendium

The Press Release — When and Why

- A press release should be issued **every time** NSO Nepal publishes data with public significance.

What it must do:

- Released **simultaneously** with the main statistical publication.
- Sent **directly** to journalists, news portals, social media teams.
- Contain **one or two headline numbers** — not the full dataset.
- Written so a journalist can reproduce the story almost word for word.

Common Mistake: Issuing a press release *days after* the bulletin, when journalists have already sourced data elsewhere — often incorrectly. **Timing is everything.**

Practical Example: NLFS 2082

One survey → five different documents:

Order	Document	Type	Audience
1	Sampling & Field Operations Report	Technical/Methodology	Statisticians (intern
2	NLFS 2082 Main Report	Survey Report	All stakeholders
3	Youth Unemployment — Thematic Analysis	Analytical Report	Policymakers, don
4	NLFS 2082 Launch Announcement	Press Release	Media, public
5	Labour Market Brief for Ministry	Policy Brief	Ministry of Labour

Key Takeaway: The report type is determined by *who reads it* and *what they need to do with it*.

Step 3 of 7

Structuring the Outline

How to plan a report's skeleton before writing — and why structure matters for credibility.

Why Outlining Comes First

Writing without an outline is like **building a house without a blueprint.**

A solid outline:

- Ensures no critical section is missed.
- Lets multiple authors divide the work clearly.
- Prevents the report from growing in unplanned directions.
- Makes peer review and editing much faster.

Rule: Always outline *before* you write. The investment pays back tenfold in writing speed and quality.

The Universal Outline Framework

1. Front Matter

- Title page
- Foreword / Preface
- Table of Contents
- List of Tables & Figures
- Abbreviations

2. Introductory Section

- Background / Context
- Objectives
- Scope & Coverage

3. Core Content

- Methodology
- Findings / Results
- Analysis / Interpretation

4. Concluding Section

- Summary / Conclusions
- Recommendations (where applicable)

5. Back Matter

- References
- Annexes / Appendices
- Glossary

Outlines by Report Type

Statistical Bulletin

Cover → Key Highlights →
Data Tables →
Short Analytical Notes →
Methodology Note → Contact

Press Release

Headline → Dateline →
Opening paragraph (the news) →
Key findings (2–3 paragraphs) →
Context → NSO Chief Quote →
Boilerplate → Contact

Analytical Report

Cover → Foreword →
Executive Summary →
Introduction →
Data Sources & Methods →
Thematic Findings →
Conclusions & Recommendations →
References → Annexes

Policy Brief

Title → Key Message →
Background →
Evidence (2–3 findings) →
Policy Options →
Recommended Action →
Further Reading

Building Your Outline — 5 Steps

1. **Start with purpose** — Write one sentence:
"This report will help [audience] understand/decide [X]."
2. **List the questions your reader will have** — your sections should answer each one.
3. **Group related questions** into logical chapters or sections.
4. **Order them** — general to specific, or context → findings → recommendations.
5. **Assign approximate length** — so you know where the weight falls.

NSO Nepal Tip: For census/survey reports, check UNFPA, UNICEF, or UN Statistics Division templates first.

Key Takeaway: An outline is not a table of contents — it is a *thinking tool*.

Step 4 of 7

What to Include in Each Section

The anatomy of a well-written official report — section by section.

Front Matter Sections

Section	What to Include
Title Page	Report title, subtitle, NSO Nepal, date/period, edition, GoN emblem
Foreword / Preface	Importance of the report, thanks to contributors, no findings (1–2 paragraphs)
Executive Summary	Stand-alone summary; purpose + key findings + recommendations; written last ; 1–2 pages
Table of Contents	Auto-generated; must match actual section headings and page numbers
Abbreviations	All acronyms defined in one place

Important: The **Executive Summary** is the most-read section of any long report. A reader who reads *only this* must understand the report's main message.

Core Content Sections

Introduction / Background answers:

- Why was this report written?
- What time period, geography, and population does it cover?
- How does it connect to previous reports in the series?

Methodology / Data Sources must include:

- Data source(s): survey, census, administrative records, satellite data.
- Sample design: sampling frame, sample size, stratification.
- Data collection period and methods.
- Processing steps: editing, imputation, weighting.
- **Key limitations and caveats.**

Findings / Results — structured by thematic chapters or indicator sections. Each finding needs: **the number** → **comparison** → **interpretation** → **supporting table/chart**.

Analytical and Closing Sections

Analysis / Discussion

Goes beyond numbers to explain them objectively:

- What patterns emerge?
- Are there regional, gender, or income-level differences?
- How does this compare to other countries or previous surveys?

Conclusions and Recommendations

- **Conclusions** = what the data *shows*.
- **Recommendations** = what should be *done (only when the brief calls for it)*.

Annexes

House technical material that would slow down the main text:
full data tables · survey questionnaires · sampling frame details · definitions & classifications.

The Press Release — Section by Section

Press Release Structure

[NSO NEPAL LOGO / LETTERHEAD]

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE

Date: Baisakh 15, 2082 / 28 April 2025

HEADLINE: Nepal's Inflation Rises to 6.2% in Baisakh 2082

(One sentence · factual · newsworthy)

KATHMANDU - [Opening paragraph: single most important fact in plain language. What, when, how much?]

[Body paragraph 1: Second most important finding + comparison to prior period]

[Body paragraph 2: Context - what is driving the change?]

``Quote,`` said [Name], Chief Statistician, NSO Nepal.

Contact: [Name · Title · Email · Phone]

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The Golden Rule of Press Releases

Inverted Pyramid Structure

Most important → least important, top to bottom.

Journalists cut from the **bottom**. If trimmed, the headline + opening paragraph must still tell the complete story.



Step 5 of 7

Writing with Statistical Precision

How to present numbers, analysis, and language accurately and accessibly.

Principle 1 — Let the Number Lead

Always give the actual number first. Never lead with vague adjectives.

*"There has been a **significant** upward trend in price levels."*

*"Consumer prices rose by **6.2%** year-on-year in Baisakh 2082, up from **5.8%** in Chaitra 2081."*

Avoid these vague words in statistical writing:

Vague Word	Replace with...
significant	[actual number]
high / low	[number + context]
considerable	[number + comparison]
dramatic change	[before figure] → [after figure]

Principle 2 — Be Precise About What You Measure

Every number must be anchored in **three dimensions**:

Dimension	Question to answer	Example
Indicator	What exactly is being measured?	Unemployment <i>rate</i> (not persons)
Reference period	When?	Baisakh 2082 (Nepali) = April/May
Population	Who is included?	Persons aged 15+, all 77 districts

Principle 3 — Percentage vs. Percentage Points

This is the most common error in statistical writing.

Scenario: Inflation moves from 5% to 6%.

Change:

- **Correct:** Rose by **1 percentage point**
- **Incorrect:** Rose by 1% ← **WRONG**

A 1% *increase* in a 5% rate is:

$$5\% \times 1.01 = 5.05\% \quad (\text{not } 6\%)$$

Why it matters:

Getting this wrong causes journalists to misreport your figure by a **factor of 5**.

Always say:

“rose by X percentage points”

not *“rose by X percent”* when measuring a change in a rate.

Principles 4 & 5 — Tables and Uncertainty

Every table and figure must have:

Element	Requirement
Number	Table 3.1, Figure 2
Title	Fully self-describing (no need to read the text)
Unit	% · Rs · persons · thousands — in the header
Source line	<i>Source: NSO Nepal, NLFS 2082</i>
Notes	Footnotes for exclusions, rounding, caveats

- Keep tables **in the text near where they are referenced** — don't hide them in annexes.
- **Qualify uncertainty honestly** — margins of error, small sample size warnings, and data quality flags. Transparency is a mark of credibility, not weakness.

Precision in Press Releases

Rule	Example
Round intelligently in headlines	"about 1.2 million persons" not "1,213,447"
Give precise figures in the body	Full number in paragraph 2 or linked table
Anchor comparisons	"fell from 25.2% in 2010/11 to 17.4% in 2022/23"
Define technical terms	"labour force participation rate (<i>the share of working-age population employed or actively seeking work</i>)"

Key Takeaway: Precision is not about complexity — it is about *exactness*. Numbers must be anchored in time, population, and units. Vague statistical writing erodes public trust.

Step 6 of 7

Review, Quality Assurance, and Finalization

Building a multi-stage QA process that protects NSO Nepal's institutional credibility.

Why QA Is Non-Negotiable

A statistical report published with **one error** — a wrong number, a mislabelled table, an inconsistency between text and chart — damages the credibility of the institution, not just the author.

For NSO Nepal — **custodian of Nepal's official statistics** — every report represents the office's reputation.

Types of errors to catch:

- Numerical mismatch between text and tables.
- Wrong percentage/percentage point distinction.
- Inconsistent time period labelling.
- Mislabeled tables or figures.
- Executive summary inconsistent with findings.

QA Checklist — Factual & Consistency

Factual / Data Accuracy

- ☐ All numbers in text match numbers in tables.
- ☐ Comparisons to previous periods are correct.
- ☐ Totals and sub-totals cross-checked.
- ☐ Percentage change calculations verified.

Consistency

- ☐ Same number written the same way throughout.
- ☐ Table and figure numbers sequential & correctly referenced.
- ☐ Time periods described consistently.

Language and Clarity

- ☐ Executive summary matches findings.
- ☐ All jargon defined on first use.

QA Checklist — Formatting & Press Release

Formatting and Style

- ☐ NSO Nepal house style applied (fonts, logos, page numbering).
- ☐ All tables/figures properly titled and sourced.
- ☐ Table of Contents is up to date.
- ☐ PDF named correctly (e.g., *NSO_CPI_Baisakh2082_Final.pdf*).

Press Release — Specific Checks

- ☐ Headline accurately reflects the most important number.
- ☐ Dated and marked “For Immediate Release”.
- ☐ Contact details included.
- ☐ Quote reviewed and approved by the senior official.

The Review Workflow



- **For major publications** (census, survey reports), also consider:
 - **External expert review** — international consultants, academic peers.
 - **Pre-publication stakeholder consultation** — relevant ministries.

Finalization Checklist — Before Publishing

Item	Status
All data verified against source datasets	[☐]
Final text approved by Chief Statistician	[☐]
Press release prepared and ready to send simultaneously	[☐]
PDF locked and named correctly	[☐]
Report uploaded to NSO Nepal website with correct metadata	[☐]
Press release distributed to media list	[☐]
Social media posts scheduled (if applicable)	[☐]

Key Takeaway: QA is a process, not a single proofread. Build review stages into your production schedule as planned milestones — not afterthoughts.

Step 7 of 7

Synthesis: From Blank Page to Published Report

Applying all six steps to a real NSO Nepal publication scenario.

Worked Example: CPI Baisakh 2082

Situation: End of Baisakh. Monthly CPI data processing is complete. You manage the publication from start to finish.

Stage 1 — Identify what to produce (Step 2)

Document	Type	Audience
CPI Monthly Bulletin	Statistical Bulletin	Government, researchers, public
Press Release	Press Release	Media, general public
Internal Briefing Note	Administrative Report	Chief Statistician / NPC

Stage 2 — Build the Outline (Step 3)

CPI Bulletin Outline

Cover → Key Highlights Box →
1. Introduction → 2. Overall CPI →
3. Food Inflation → 4. Non-Food →
5. Regional Breakdown →
6. Methodology Note → Data Tables
→ Contact

Press Release Outline

Headline (overall CPI + change) →
Opening paragraph (headline in plain
English) → Food inflation →
Regional highlight → Context →
NSO Chief Quote → Boilerplate → Con-
tact

Stage 3 — Write for Each Audience (Steps 4 & 5)

Statistical Bulletin

- Full methodology note.
- Precise tables with source lines.
- Percentage point language throughout.
- Comparison to previous month & year.

Internal Briefing Note

- Bullet points only.
- 1 page maximum.
- Summary + 2–3 recommendations.
- No methodology detail needed.

Press Release

- One headline number up top.
- Plain language, no jargon.
- Round headline figures.
- One NSO Chief quote in plain language.
- Methodology in one sentence.
- “For Immediate Release” header.

Stage 4 — Review & Publish (Step 6)

Peer reviewer checks all figures match the source data



Manager reviews press release quote accuracy



Chief Statistician signs off



10:00 AM — Publication Day: Bulletin + Press Release + Web update released simultaneously

Note: Simultaneous release is critical. If the press release goes out before the report is on the website, journalists cannot verify the numbers themselves.

The Mental Model — Always



Every official report — from a **2-page press release** to a **300-page census** — follows the same logic.

The **scale** changes.
The **thinking** does not.

Master this workflow and you can confidently approach any official report at NSO Nepal.

Summary — What You Now Know

Step	Key Idea
1	Reports differ by type — identify the right one before writing
2	Audience + purpose + occasion → determines report type; press releases accompany every major release
3	Outline before you write — it is a thinking tool, not just a contents page
4	Every section has a specific job; press releases follow the inverted pyramid
5	Anchor numbers in time, population, and units; distinguish % from percentage points
6	QA is multi-stage — build it into your production schedule
7	All steps form a repeatable workflow from blank page to published report

Where to Go From Here

1. International Standards

UN Statistics Division guidelines, IMF Data Standards (SDDS), and how they shape NSO Nepal norms.

2. Data Visualisation

Designing tables, charts, and infographics that meet accessibility and publication standards.

3. Plain Language

Making statistical findings understandable and accessible to non-technical audiences.

Thank You

National Statistics Office Nepal
Government of Nepal

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